

Circuits of Salt: Commodities, Networks, and Politics of Trade in 20th Century Himalayas

ABSTRACT

Salt has long sustained Himalayan economies, shaped ritual life, and structured multi-commodity exchange networks across Himalayas and much of Highland Asia. While often studied for its economic and anthropological significance, salt also functioned as political infrastructure. Thus, salt shaped sovereignty, taxation, mobility, and governance across the region. This study investigates whether salt routes in Ladakh and Western Tibet served as the structural backbone of multi-commodity trade networks over the last two and a half centuries. Drawing from colonial gazetteers, administrative reports, treaties, and archival records, the paper combines historical analysis with computational text-processing methods such as Named Entity Recognition (NER) and relation extraction models. The findings aim to reconceptualize salt not as a mere commodity, but as an infrastructure of governance embedded within imperial regulation and frontier politics.

METHODOLOGY

This study follows a three-stage archival and computational framework to analyse Himalayan salt networks. First, a historical corpus of gazetteers, treaties, and administrative reports is cleaned, normalised, and converted into structured text. The corpus is processed using NER via TextRazor, generating entities with confidence and relevance scores to distinguish central trade-related actors from peripheral mentions. Second, topic modelling is applied to identify dominant historical themes such as governance, mobility, and taxation. These themes are manually refined and examined through co-occurrence analysis (± 50 -word windows) to detect recurring associations between commodities, communities, and institutions. Finally, relation extraction generates Subject–Relation–Object triples which will be used to build a relational network graph. Nodes would be salt sources, communities, routes, and state institutions, while edges capture extraction and taxation links.

CASE STUDY: RUPSHU & TSO KAR BASIN

The Rupshu plateau and Tso Kar salt lake in eastern Ladakh constitute a major Himalayan salt extraction zone. Seasonal evaporation produces salt deposits that sustain pastoral groups such as the Rupshu and Changpas, integrating salt harvesting with herding and caravan trade. Extraction was socially regulated: male work groups operated under local supervision of *kotwal*, with quotas and assigned lake sections. Salt functioned as a medium of exchange for barley, wool, and pashm, linking high-altitude pastoralism to agrarian and monastic centres. Conflicts over access to Tso Kar, between *Rupshu nomads* and *Kharnak* backed by *Himis* group, and later colonial licensing systems reveal that control over salt meant control over mobility and political authority. The *Rupshu–Tso Kar* region thus exemplifies the transformation of salt from a kinship-regulated exchange system into a contested political infrastructure between the end of 18th century and the end of 20th century .

"Rupshupa – Collect – salt from Tso Kar"

"Salt – Barter – for Barley"

"Ladakh Buddhist Association – Reached Settlement Between – Kharnak & Rupshu"

Fig 1. Examples of Subject-Relation-Object Triplet

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CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORKS

Network modelling establishes salt as the central node linking commodities such as tea, pashm, wool, and grain, confirming that salt routes functioned as the structural backbone of multi-commodity exchange in the Western Himalayas. Strong connections emerge between extraction sites, pastoral communities and state institutions, with corridors such as *Rupshu–TsoKar–Leh* operating as regulatory bottlenecks. Topic modelling reveals a clear shift from precolonial vocabularies of reciprocity and *netsang* to colonial terms of duty, permits, and monopoly. These findings firmly position salt routes as political infrastructures that shaped sovereignty, mobility, and frontier governance than mere trade networks.

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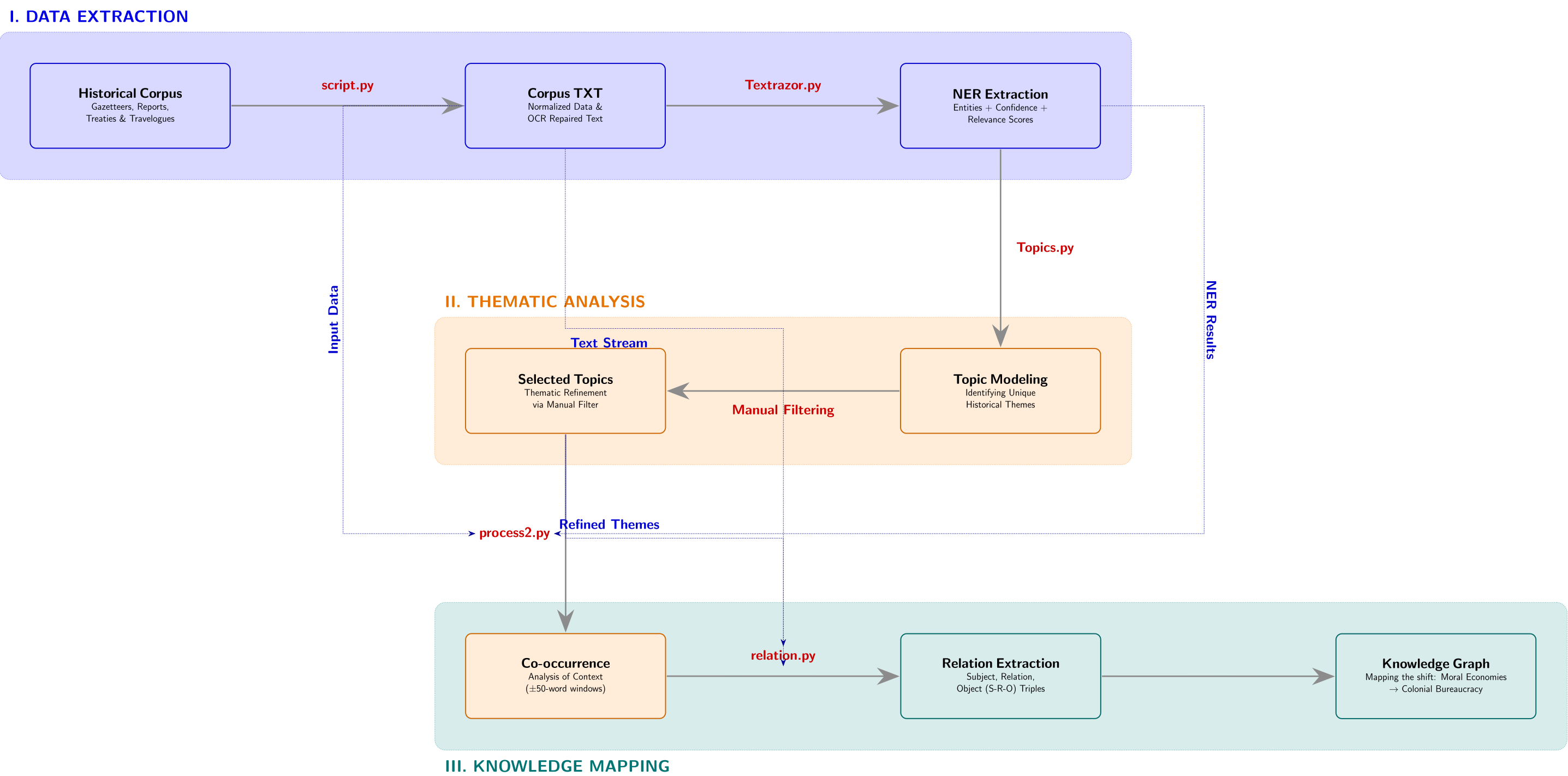


Fig 2. Archival-to-Network Methodological Pipeline for Analysing Himalayan Salt Trade.